

St. Mark's Basilica

An exotic church in Venice glittering with golden mosaics and filled with cultural treasures



In 832 CE, two Venetian merchants presented the Doge of Venice with the purported body of St. Mark, which they had stolen from a tomb in Alexandria. The doge had a basilica built to house this sacred relic. The current basilica is the third church erected on the site. Constructed between 1063 and 1094, it served for centuries as the doge's private chapel and a setting for Venetian state ceremonies until belatedly assigned the role of Cathedral of Venice in 1807.

Byzantine influence

The basilica's five domes and the rounded arches of its facade have a distinctly eastern look, reflecting medieval Venice's close relations with the Byzantine empire. The interior glows with gold glass mosaics—mostly dating from the 12th to 14th centuries—that cover the walls and domed ceilings with vivid scenes from the Bible. The undulating, tessellated marble floor, with its bold geometric patterns and images of animals and birds, contributes to the overwhelming decorative effect.

The basilica is a treasure trove of unique cultural artifacts, some older than the building itself. Part of the glittering Pala d'Oro, an altarpiece composed of pieces of enamel set in gold leaf and almost 2,000 precious stones, dates from the 10th century. The four bronze horses of St. Mark, known as the Quadriga, which stand above the main portal on the basilica's facade, were made at the time of the ancient Roman empire, probably around 200 CE. The Quadriga was brought to Venice as loot from the sack of Constantinople (present-day Istanbul) by the Venetian-financed Fourth Crusade in 1204. The ancient Roman porphyry statue of four linked figures known as the *Portrait of the Tetrarchs*, which stands outside the basilica, is another looted artifact from Constantinople.

Retaining character

There have been later additions, such as the 15th-century Gothic pinnacles and 19th-century mosaics that have altered the facade. However, despite such changes and the impact of modern tourism, the basilica has preserved its atmosphere of age-old sanctity.

The **mosaics** inside St. Mark's cover a **total area of 43,000 square ft (4,000 square m)**



◀ MOSAIC OF THE CRUCIFIXION

The mosaics in the basilica illustrate scenes from the Old and New Testaments of the Bible. This mosaic is a traditional representation of Jesus's Crucifixion.

▷ FINE FACADE

The basilica's lavish facade is topped by a statue of St. Mark, with the winged lion—the emblem of the saint and of Venice—below him. The four horses are replicas of originals kept in the basilica's museum.

